

The Machete and the Mirror: Why Hannah Diamond's Plastic Pop is More Human Than You Think

From the "Poke Bass" to the psychology of Auto-Tune, we're dissecting the meticulously engineered sweetness of the PC Music universe.

1. The Hook: A Relatable Curiosity

There is a weary tendency among the self-appointed "musically serious" to dismiss Bubblegum Bass as the sonic equivalent of a computer that spent a weekend bingeing Balenciaga campaigns and digital nihilism. With its high-gloss synths, formant-shifted vocals, and relentless consumerist imagery, it is often labeled as synthetic, simple, or—heaven forbid—unauthentic. It sounds like a sentient algorithm trying to explain a crush, which is exactly why so many listeners miss the point entirely. The reality is that this "plastic" pop is a marvel of high-level engineering. To create something that feels this surreal and ear-grabbingly minimalist requires a degree of technical precision and psychological manipulation that would make a traditional rock producer weep into their analog tape. Far from being "fake," the world of PC Music—pioneered by the likes of A.G. Cook, the late SOPHIE, and Charli XCX—uses digital tools to explore a very human duality: the tension between the satirical and the sincere.

2. The Art of the Machete: Why "Working by Subtraction" is the Secret to Minimalism

In traditional analog recording, the philosophy is additive. You start with a guitar and drums, then you pile on the overdubs, the strings, and the backing vocals until you have a wall of sound. However, the PC Music ethos, as practiced by A.G. Cook and George Daniel, flips this script through a digital-first method known as "working by subtraction." Instead of building a track brick by brick, these producers often fill a Logic Pro session with loops and layers, only to take a metaphorical machete to the arrangement. This isn't just a technical choice; it's an act of bravery. It takes a certain kind of confidence to delete a track you spent four hours perfecting just because the song breathes better without it. The result is a sound punctuated by abrupt silences—moments where the listener's brain expects a climax but finds only a beautifully curated void. "It takes emotional strength to use the delete button assertively. It's painful to work on something and then erase it... even if it's practically easy to take a metaphorical machete to your music in a DAW, it still requires confidence."

3. The Auto-Tune Mirror: It's Not About Fixing Notes, It's About Finding Confidence

The general public views Auto-Tune as a crutch for the tone-deaf, but for artists like Charli XCX, it functions as a psychological shield. In the studio, Charli often records with real-time pitch correction blasting through her headphones. When every note you sing comes back sounding "perfect," it acts as a mirror that reflects a more confident version of yourself. This isn't about laziness; it's about creating a "party atmosphere" in the cold, clinical environment of the studio. By removing the immediate fear of singing a "wrong" note, the artist is freed up to try experimental melodies they might otherwise be too shy to attempt. As Charli famously sums up her studio ethos: *"I drink and I smoke and I use Auto-Tune."* It is a deliberate choice to prioritize vibe and raw emotional output over the dry, scrutinized accuracy of raw vocal control.

4. The "Poke Bass" and the Power of the Click

One of the most characteristic sounds in the Bubblegum Bass palette is the "Poke Bass," a technique with roots in the meticulously clean 1980s production of Scritti Politti. To achieve a bass that is both "fat" and capable of cutting through a dense digital mix, producers layer two distinct sound sources to manipulate "timbre"—essentially the "color" of a sound that allows you to tell a piano and a guitar apart even when they play the same note. First, they use an FM synth (the classic Yamaha DX7 is the gold standard here) to create a percussive, "clicky" attack with almost no sustain. Then, they layer this with a big, round analog bass sound from a Minimoog. The DX7 provides the "poke" that lets the sound be heard on tiny iPhone speakers, while the Moog provides the sub-frequency foundation that shakes the club. **Pro Tip:** If your low end feels muddy, stop adding volume. Instead, add a high-frequency "click" at the start of the note. It gives the ear a target to hit while the analog sub does the heavy lifting.

5. Formant Shifting: Designing the Uncanny Valley

To get that "childlike" or "saccharine" vocal quality, producers rely on formant shifting. It is crucial to distinguish this from simple pitch shifting. Pitch shifting changes the musical note, which often creates a comical "chipmunk" effect. Formant shifting, however, changes the tone color by simulating a change in the size of the vocal tract (the throat and mouth) without changing the note itself. But the "plastic" feel goes deeper than just the voice. In tracks like "I Think About It All The Time," producers use a technique called **Note On Rand** within synths like Serum. This applies a randomized filter cutoff every time a new chord is played. It ensures that the synthetic, "plastic" sounds are constantly morphing, adding a layer of organic unpredictability to an otherwise rigid digital landscape. It's the sound of a machine trying to breathe.

6. The Rhythmic "Fake-Out": Why Your Brain Loves Being Wrong-Footed

The track "360" is a masterclass in rhythmic tension. Producers create a pattern and repeat it just enough times to train your brain to expect the next beat, and then they simply leave a "hole." In "360," a high-note pattern repeats three times, but on the fourth, the "anchor" note disappears. This "wrong-footing" keeps the listener in a state of constant attention. It's a technique that works on a primal level; music educator Ethan Hein notes that even his toddlers love "360" for its playfulness. The music isn't just for the avant-garde elite; it's built on the universal human joy of being surprised. **How to spot a fake-out:**

- **Repeated Patterns:** Listen for a loop that plays exactly three times.
- **Sudden Gaps:** Notice if the "foundation" note disappears on the fourth repetition.
- **Unexpected Substitutions:** Watch for moments where a heavy kick drum is replaced by something fragile, like a flurry of handclaps.

7. Harmonic Ambiguity: The "Too Sweet to Be True" Effect

Musically, Bubblegum Bass often flirts with "Lydian lifts." This involves moving from a standard major key to the Lydian mode, which features a sharp fourth. This one note adds a "dystopian sci-fi" or cinematic sheen to a song, making the melody feel "too sweet to be true." In "Sympathy is a Knife"—a track fans speculate is fueled by Charli's insecurities regarding Taylor Swift—the production uses harmony to signal an internal struggle. While the song hammers an E-flat major chord, the high-pitched string synth pedals a B-flat that directly fights against the F chords in the chorus. This "tense rub" of the B-flat note against

the melody suggests a person desperately struggling to hold it together emotionally. It's the sound of a human heartbeat trapped inside a diamond-encrusted cage.

8. Conclusion: A Forward-Looking Summary

The techniques of Bubblegum Bass—subtractive editing, psychological Auto-Tuning, and surgical sound design—have fundamentally altered the "Hyperpop" landscape. By exaggerating the tropes of the mainstream, these producers have reached a deeper truth: that our digital lives are just as messy and emotional as our physical ones. As our world becomes increasingly synthetic, we have to recognize that the "sincerity" we crave isn't found in the lack of processing, but in the **bravery of the edit**. The act of taking a machete to a perfect track is the most human act of all. Is the future of music about raw, unedited honesty, or is it found in the confidence required to meticulously design our own reality? xoxo
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